

A SHORT NOTE FOR FOUNDERS

How is your boutique firm *handling the exponential age?*

Alexandre Olive

ELIA ATELIER · APRIL 2026

FOR

Boutique firms *serving* *demanding* clients.

Watchmakers. Jewellers. Wedding designers. Real-estate, wealth and law boutiques. Clinics. Ateliers. Longevity practices. Private architects.

You have been
seeing it.

THE SIGNS

A client asks you something your team used to research for two hours. The client got it from ChatGPT in ninety seconds.

A younger client mentions AI agents the way he used to mention email.

Three of your competitors suddenly have cleaner websites and faster responses.

Your accountant's software writes its own footnotes. Your phone summarises your meetings.

It's shifting fast.

A NOTE FROM ONE FOUNDER TO ANOTHER

I am writing it
as one of you.

I run two activities. The advice in this paper is what I
am applying to my own businesses this week.
Practice — not theory.

SECTION ONE

What changed,
in plain words.

Three terms to have straight before we go further.

THREE TERMS

AI.

The catch-all. Chatbots, image and video tools, prediction systems. When most people say *AI* in 2026, they mean the next two terms.

LLM.

Large language model. The engine underneath most of the new tools. A fast writer, reader, and researcher with no values or taste of its own. ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini.

Agents.

LLMs given the ability to take actions. Book a meeting, send an email, fill a form, search the web, make a purchase. New in 2025–26. The thing everyone is watching.

FOUR LINES TELL THE WHOLE ARC

2022. The models got good enough that normal people could use them.

2024. They got reliable enough for real business work.

2025. The cost dropped roughly tenfold.

2026. They started doing things on your behalf, not just answering questions.

That is the whole story.

SECTION TWO

Why this matters *for your firm.*

Three realities to hold together.

REALITY ONE — YOUR CLIENT IS ALREADY USING IT

45%

of consumers used AI in some part of their buying journey, January 2026.

IBM INSTITUTE FOR BUSINESS VALUE

Shopping queries on AI platforms grew 4,700% 2024 → 2025

AN EXERCISE — COSTS NOTHING, TELLS YOU EVERYTHING

They are also *asking the AI*
about you.

Open ChatGPT now. Type your firm's name. Then
ask: "*Who are the leading firms in [your category]
in [your city]?*"

If you are absent, or described inaccurately, or
described in a way that makes you sound like
everyone else — that is the first piece of work.

REALITY TWO — WHAT YOUR HNW CLIENT WANTS

Three things,
above all.

- **Managed expectations.**
- **A relationship** with specific people.
- **Convenience** — meaning their time respected.

AI delivers all three — when used with care.

KLAUS, JOURNAL OF PRODUCT & BRAND MANAGEMENT

SPENDING IS MOVING

Away from *pure status*.
Toward *what restores*.

Wellness, longevity, health, aesthetics, time in beautiful places. BCG calls it the "*health as wealth*" mindset and projects double-digit growth in those categories while traditional luxury flattens.

It reframes what you are *actually* selling.

REALITY THREE

Smallness is now *an advantage.*

LVMH spends years aligning seventy-five brands. A ten-person firm can decide on Monday and ship by Friday.

A €5M project from 2022 now costs *€40 to 150K.*

EUROSTAT 2025 — EUROPEAN AI USAGE

55%
of large European firms use AI.

17%
of small firms do.

The gap is the opportunity.

The cost has *collapsed*.
The technology *works*.

The next eighteen months
decide who runs the
next decade.

SECTION THREE

Three things *nobody*
tells you.

ONE. MOST AI PROJECTS FAIL AT THE PILOT

70–80%

across all industries.

90% in fashion. Not because the technology fails — because the teams do not know what problem they are solving, and rarely plan for the human side.

Starting small and well beats starting big and fast. Always.

MCKINSEY · GARTNER · IBM COHORTS

TWO. IMPLEMENTATIONS FAIL AT THE HUMAN LAYER

This is grief,
not resistance.

Picture the senior salesperson who has spent eighteen years writing letters to her clients in her own voice — asked to let a machine draft them.

The atelier head whose juniors used to come to him for research that now takes seconds.

The marketing coordinator who learns that the part of her job she trained for is the part the machine does best.

Training alone does not solve it. The work is to *honour what is being given up* before celebrating what is being gained.

THREE. WHAT MAKES YOU DEFENSIBLE IS NOT THE TECHNOLOGY

The technology *is rented.*

Anyone can buy your ChatGPT subscription.

Your know-how, archives, reputation, client relationships, aesthetic, judgment — these are what make you *irreplaceable*.

AI used well encodes and protects those assets. AI used badly turns them into the same beige output as everyone else.

SECTION FOUR

Where to start.

Two moves.

You do not need more than this to begin. Everything else can wait.

MOVE ONE

A private AI assistant *for your team.*

Trained on your documents, client FAQs,
institutional knowledge. Used for drafts, research,
translation, meeting notes, proposal language.

Saves each person *2 to 6 hours* a week. Pays back
within three months in almost every case.

MOVE TWO

Be findable *in AI search.*

When a client asks ChatGPT, Claude, or Gemini for *"the best private-client lawyer in Geneva," "a watchmaker who restores my grandfather's pocket watch," "a discreet wealth boutique in Zurich"* — you want to be in the answer.

The discipline is called *Generative Engine Optimisation*. It is the SEO of the next decade. Most of your competitors are not paying attention. That window will close.

Two moves. Six months.

You will be ahead of **90%** of your peers.
You will have the foundation to build whatever
comes next.

THEN, THE MOVE THAT MAKES YOU SINGULAR

Every serious house
had
one signature
instrument.

A bottle. A case-back. A scent formula. A room. A ritual. That one thing did more for the brand than a hundred campaigns — because it was the story and the product and the proof, all at once.

In this decade, that instrument is a digital product built on AI and shaped to your craft. A product, not a chatbot.

WHERE MOST FIRMS SHOULD START

Two things, *working together.*

- **A client memory layer.** Holds everything the firm knows about each client across every interaction.
- **An automated proposal system.** Drafts in the founder's voice, draws on the house's archive, produces a personalised document the senior salesperson can refine in an hour rather than a day.

€40–80K *to build · runs three to five years · pays back within three to six months.*

FOUR THINGS TO AVOID

- **Do not hire a Chief AI Officer.** Not under a hundred employees. Hire one experienced person, fractional, six months.
- **Do not chase the shiny.** Digital twins, virtual showrooms, NFT loyalty, AI influencers. Most of it is not for you yet. Say "*not yet*" without saying "*never*."
- **Do not let the founder be the only person who understands it.** Within six months, a second person must know how it works.
- **Do not skip the governance.** A Brand AI Charter, a Refusals Register, a record of AI literacy training. From *2 August 2026* the EU AI Act is binding.

THE QUESTION WORTH ASKING

Not *"should we do AI?"*
Ask instead:

What in my firm is being done by a good person at fifteen percent of their skill and eighty percent of their day?

Find three of those. Free up the hours. Give them back to your best people and your best clients.

That is the whole strategy. The rest is sequencing.

A NOTE ABOUT WHO IS WRITING THIS

Thirteen years inside luxury.
A decade *walking with*
founders.

I spent thirteen years as a VP in high jewellery, watching how the most accomplished founders carried what they built and what it cost them.

ELIA Atelier exists because small firms serving wealthy clients have a once-in-a-decade window — and most of them are going to miss it.

Not for lack of money. For lack of someone who understands both their world and this one.

A FIRST CONVERSATION

Private. Thirty minutes. *Without a deck.*

We meet, we look at your situation honestly, and we part well whether or not the next step is with us. You will know inside twenty minutes whether this is for you.

BOOK A CONVERSATION →

Alexandre Olive

ELIA Atelier · alexandre@eliaatelier.ch

